HER TAKE

"There has never been a better time to be a woman entrepreneur—or an entrepreneur—in India. Have the courage to chase your dreams"

Setting a High Bar

SUHASINI SAMPATH, 43
Co-founder, Yoga Bar
Bengaluru

Growing up in a typical South Indian family with a strong emphasis on academics, sisters Suhasini Sampath and Anindita Sampath, co-founders of Bengaluru-based Sproutlife Foods, which owns the Yoga Bar brand, were taught to always strive for excellence. "Have you done enough?" was a question their father frequently asked. He believed that everyone, irrespective of gender, should be independent.



"You have only yourself to rely on," he would often tell them. This philosophy not only shaped their family values but also nurtured their intellectual curiosity and love for learning.

It was this curiosity that led them to spot a gap in India's packaged food market. While in New York, where Suhasini was studying and Anindita was working, they had easy access to wholesome snack bars and healthy breakfast options, but found few comparable products in India. Determined to change that, the sisters returned home and spent nearly three years developing nutritious, convenient foods made with clean ingredients. At the same time, Suhasini, in 2012, founded FinAdvantage, an accounting services firm for startups, which gave her first-hand experience in fundraising, scaling businesses and working closely with entrepreneurs. It became a crucial learning ground before starting her second venture.

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Suhasini transformed Yoga Bar from a single energy bar into one of India's leading health food brands

In August 2015, the sisters launched Yoga Bar with a multigrain energy bar, which went on to become the company's bestselling product. Today, Yoga Bar offers muesli, oats, protein bars, plant protein, protein shakes, peanut butter, dry fruits, seeds and quinoa, among other products, which are available in more than 7,500 stores across over 30 cities and are exported to Nepal, Sri Lanka, the Maldives and the UAE.

The company attracted marquee investors, including Fireside Ventures and Elevation Capital, enabling it to scale nationally. In 2023, FMCG major ITC acquired a 39.4 per cent stake in Sproutlife Foods as part of a phased acquisition that is expected to culminate in full ownership over the next few years for a value of Rs 500 crore.

Having led the business until May, Suhasini is now looking ahead to her next entrepreneurial venture. And she knows it will be a consumer brand, an area she is most passionate about building. ■

— Sonal Khetarpal